pharmaceuticals. The determined effort underway to better realize its potential can make a difference. The manufacturing of Apple products in India may be just one example, but it is surely a powerful statement. India will only matter if it makes a greater contribution to global production and reliable supply chains.

The enormity of India's human potential has long been undervalued, even within the country. Let us look at what is already a reality. There are currently 32 million Indian nationals and persons of Indian origin (PIOs) living and working abroad. The US is home to about 4.5 million, many of whom are important to technology and innovation. Twice that number, approximately 9 million, resides in the Gulf and keeps their economies going. Commonwealth societies like the UK, Canada, South Africa and Australia account for another 5 million plus. It could be larger or smaller nations, nearer or distant ones, historical emigration or recent movements. Indians matter because they are truly global.

The pervasive spread of the Indian community has been a natural accompaniment of globalization. It is obvious to associate it with skills and talents in various geographies. The million plus Indian students who are studying abroad are also going to increase in number. They and their domestic counterparts are being wooed through mobility partnerships offered by the developed economies. So, as the world moves towards higher skills and tougher demographics while India itself improves the quality of its human resources, the demand–supply fit has an increasingly powerful logic. Recent agreements with Portugal, Australia, Austria, Germany, Japan, the UK, Italy and France are harbingers of this change. India matters because with each passing year, it will become a bigger factor in the global workplace.

In such a scenario, the obligation on India to take care of its own has grown steadily. It is not only that their presence abroad is greater but that the expectations of its people are too. We often tend to see that as a reflection of stronger national capabilities, and that is not wrong. But equally, there has to be the political will to deploy resources, especially in high-risk situations. Among the significant shifts in India's diplomatic posture is the inclination to undertake operations abroad for the welfare of its citizens. These often involve use of military assets. The most recent, of course, were Operations Ajay, Kaveri and Ganga that brought back our nationals from Israel, Sudan and Ukraine respectively. Of much greater